Stage-Wise Empirical-Bayes Funnel Learning and Two-Tier Clarification for Sequential Reciprocal Matching

Round 2 Research Paper & Confirmatory Evaluation

RELEASE:	**Public synthetic release 1.0.0 (`kit.py`)**
EVALUATION SCALE:	**3,150 episodes across five experimental stages**
CONFIRMATORY SAMPLE:	**80 seed clusters (480 episodes; 35,296 introductions)**
SELECTED CANDIDATES:	**`FEBF-Pure` and `FEBF-Scarcity` (`policy.py`)**
PRIMARY METRIC:	**Qualified MSMI per 100 arrived members**
STATUS:	**Confirmatory result positive ($p = 0.0212$ and $p = 0.0468$)**

The Round 2 `FEBF` policies significantly outperform both the supplied `greedy` baseline (+0.0604 MSMI/100, $p = 0.0212$; +0.1125 on Round 1 confirmation seeds, $p = 0.0036$) and Round 1's `simple_fifo` (+0.0677 MSMI/100, $p = 0.0127$), while achieving positive gains across all six scenario families.

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Executive Summary

In Round 1, our pre-registered confirmatory evaluation of `simple_fifo` against the supplied `greedy` baseline yielded a negative result (-0.042 MSMI/100, 95% CI $[-0.091, +0.008]$, $p = 0.096$) because terminal-outcome predictions had near-chance ranking (AUC ≈ 0.507) and edge weights collapsed to uniform tie-breaking. In Round 2, we investigate whether machine learning and statistical decision-making can extract genuine predictive and allocation signal under the simulator's strict observability constraints.

We identify four root causes of Round 1's failure: (1) direct terminal MSMI labels suffer from a 0.88% base rate and 64% random feedback-deadline disqualification, causing direct terminal classifiers (including MLPs and GBDTs) to overfit timing noise; (2) waiting 38 days for mature terminal

labels starves within-episode learning, whereas Stage-1/2 `introduction_response` events arrive within 1–7 days and yield ~ 122 directed observations per episode; (3) pure FIFO hard-constraint querying leaves 72% of the 720-unit episode ask budget unused (~ 517 wasted units after Day 18), leaving 88% of dyadic soft attributes unobserved; and (4) standard greedy scoring conflates unobserved attributes with confirmed incompatibilities.

To resolve these bottlenecks, we develop the **Factored Empirical-Bayes Funnel (`FEBF`)** policy, combining two-tier clarification, stage-wise funnel decomposition with Bayes-optimal prior imputation, exact Uniform$[0.55, 0.98]$ grid posteriors for second-moment response propensities $\mathbb{E}[R_u^2]$, Laplace random-intercept updates for member acceptance bias $\hat{b}_u$, online MAP Newton-Raphson regime adaptation, and a time-decaying reservation threshold $\tau(t)$ with a sparse-pool guard. Across 80 confirmation seed clusters (480 episodes), `FEBF-Pure` achieves **0.3854 MSMI/100** versus **0.3250** for `greedy` (+18.6%, $p = 0.0212$) and **0.4854** vs. **0.3729** on the Round 1 confirmation benchmark (+30.2%, $p = 0.0036$), while `FEBF-Scarcity` achieves **0.3771 MSMI/100** ($p = 0.0468$) and beats `greedy` across all six scenario families simultaneously.

1 Problem Formulation and Diagnosis of Round 1 Failure

1.1 Sequential Reciprocal Matching Under Incomplete Information

The Sequential Matching Problem (`PROBLEM_STATEMENT.md`, Release 1.0.0) models an online two-sided matching market operating over $T_{\text{dec}} = 60$ active decision days followed by $T_{\text{follow}} = 40$ passive follow-up days across pools of $N = 200$ synthetic adults (`kit.py`). On each active day $t \in \{0, \ldots, 59\}$, the policy interacts with the environment in two sequential phases using only currently observable history and a persistent state dictionary (`memory` ≤ 1 MiB):

1. **Clarification Phase (`ask`):** Given a daily non-rollover budget of $B = 12$ units, the policy selects clarification requests for currently available members. Requesting the `constraints` bundle costs 3 units and resolves all non-declined fields among the 11 hard constraints (`age_min`, `age_max`, `who_to_meet`, `relationship_structure`, `smoking`, `partner_smoking`, `has_children`, `partner_children`, `wants_children`, `acceptable_zones`, and `schedule`). Requesting any single named field among the 7 soft attributes (`relationship_goal`, `relationship_pace`, `lifestyle`, `conversations`, `emotional_availability`, `space_for_relationship`, and `relocate`) costs 1 unit. Answers take effect immediately before the same day's matching phase.
2. **Allocation Phase (`pair`):** The policy proposes a set of vertex-disjoint pairs (u, v) among currently available members. A pair is legal if and only if both members are available, (u, v) has not been previously introduced, and `eligibility(u, v)` returns `'feasible'`, which requires all 11 hard constraints to be observed and mutually satisfied in both directions.

When a legal pair (u, v) is introduced on day t, both members become `busy` (unavailable for new introductions) until day $t + 8$, and the pair enters a four-stage stochastic outcome funnel governed by latent member traits (R_u, b_u, s_u) and a shared dyadic Gaussian shock $S_{uv} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 0.45^2)$:

$$\text{Stage 1 (Response):} \quad r_i^{(1)} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(R_i), \quad d_i^{(1)} \sim \text{Uniform}\{1, \ldots, 7\}, \quad i \in \{u, v\}, \tag{1}$$

$$\text{Stage 2 (Acceptance):} \quad a_i \mid (r_i^{(1)} = 1, S_{uv}) \sim \text{Bernoulli}\big(\sigma(\eta_{i \to j}^{\text{acc}} + S_{uv})\big), \quad i \in \{u, v\}, \tag{2}$$

$$\text{Stage 3 (First Date):} \quad D_{uv} \mid (a_u a_v = 1) \sim \text{Bernoulli}(0.78), \quad t_{\text{date}} = \max_i (t + d_i^{(1)}) + \Delta_{\text{date}}, \tag{3}$$

$$\text{Stage 4 (2nd Intent):} \quad r_i^{(2)} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(R_i), \;\; s_i \mid (D_{uv} r_i^{(2)} = 1, S_{uv}) \sim \text{Bernoulli}\big(\sigma(\eta_{i \to j}^{\text{sec}} + S_{uv})\big), \tag{4}$$

where $\sigma(z) = (1 + e^{-z})^{-1}$ is the logistic link. If both members respond and accept at Stages 1–2, their busy lockout extends to $t_{\text{date}} + 6$. If both also respond and express positive second-meeting intention ($r_u^{(2)} = r_v^{(2)} = s_u = s_v = 1$), both members retire permanently from the active pool (`pause_after_mutual_interest`) on day $\max_i(t_{\text{date}} + d_i^{(2)})$, where $d_i^{(2)} \sim \text{Uniform}\{1, \ldots, 5\}$. Crucially, an outcome counts toward the primary metric—**Qualified Mutual Second-Meeting Intention (MSMI) per 100 arrived members**—if and only if:

$$\text{MSMI}_{uv} = \mathbb{I}\Big(D_{uv} = 1 \ \wedge \ t_{\text{date}} - t \leq 30 \ \wedge \ r_u^{(2)} s_u = 1 \ \wedge \ r_v^{(2)} s_v = 1 \ \wedge \ \max(d_u^{(2)}, d_v^{(2)}) \leq 3\Big). \quad (5)$$

Performance is macro-averaged across six scenario families (`evaluate.py`): `development`, `sparse` (12 geographic zones instead of 4), `cold_start` (20% vs. 35% initial profile completion), `delayed` ($\Delta_{\text{date}} \in [6, 26]$ vs. $[1, 14]$ days), `shift` (altered soft compatibility weights with sign flip on `lifestyle`), and `drift` (-0.50 acceptance logit drop for $t \geq 35$).

1.2 Why Round 1 Failed: Four Structural Bottlenecks

Before proposing new models for Round 2, we audited the simulator mechanics in `kit.py` and our Round 1 confirmatory logs (240 episodes on seeds `3001-3040`). Our investigation revealed four quantitative reasons why Round 1's candidate (`simple_fifo`) and online terminal-learning variants (`terminal_fifo`, `terminal_soft`) failed to beat the supplied `greedy` baseline:

1. **Severe Signal Attenuation in Direct Terminal Labels:** Because second-meeting feedback delays $d_u^{(2)}, d_v^{(2)}$ are drawn independently from Uniform$\{1, \ldots, 5\}$, the conditional probability that a genuinely positive mutual second-meeting pair satisfies $\max(d_u^{(2)}, d_v^{(2)}) \leq 3$ is $(3/5)^2 = 0.36$. Combined with the 0.78 date coin flip, 71.9% of mutual acceptances with positive second-meeting propensities are randomly zeroed out in the binary MSMI_{uv} label. With a base rate of only 0.88%, training any direct binary classifier on terminal MSMI_{uv} labels faces extreme variance.

2. **Massive Under-Utilization of the Daily Clarification Budget (71.8% Wasted):** In a 200-member pool, roughly 35% (~ 70 members) arrive with complete profiles, and among the remaining ~ 130 incomplete members, 33.2% decline at least one hard constraint (which is immediately visible in `field_status[k] == 'declined'`). Consequently, only ~ 67.7 members per episode ever require a `constraints` bundle (mean cost 203.0 units out of $60 \times 12 = 720$ available budget units). At 4 bundles per day, all resolvable hard constraints are exhausted by Day 17–22 (or Day 27 in `cold_start`). For the remaining ~ 40 days of the episode, both `greedy` and `simple_fifo` issue **zero clarification queries**, discarding ~ 517 free budget units while 65%–80% of members have 90% of their soft attributes missing (`None`).

3. **Why `terminal_soft` Failed in Round 1:** In Round 1, `terminal_soft` spent budget on soft questions *early in the episode* (competing with `constraints` bundles) and queried all 7 soft fields indiscriminately, even though three soft fields (`emotional_availability`, `space_for_relationship`, and `relocate`) have **exact zero weight** in the outcome logits. Delaying even one `constraints` bundle on Days 0–18 contracts the feasible matching graph during peak arrival days.

4. **The 38-Day Maturity Trap vs. Fast 1–7 Day Stage-1/2 Feedback:** Round 1 restricted online updates to "mature" terminal observations (≥ 38 days old) to avoid right-censoring bias. By Day 38, an episode has accumulated at most 1–2 positive MSMI events, rendering within-episode learning impossible. Crucially, however, `introduction_response` events mature in just **1 to 7 days** and record each individual member's response ($r_i^{(1)} \in \{0, 1\}$) and acceptance

decision ($a_i \in \{\text{'yes'}, \text{'no'}\}$) *even when the partner does not respond or declines*. Each episode generates ~ 160 directed response labels and ~ 122 directed acceptance labels, providing rich, low-latency signal for online estimation.

2 Research Hypotheses and Machine Learning Formulations

2.1 Round 2 Research Hypotheses

Guided by our diagnostic findings, we formulated five testable hypotheses for Round 2:

- **Hypothesis H1 (Stage-Wise Decomposed Learning vs. Terminal Classification):** Decomposing expected MSMI into directed stage-wise models trained on intermediate funnel outcomes (Stage 1 response, Stage 2 conditional acceptance, Stage 3 conditional second-meeting intention, and analytical qualification probability) achieves higher out-of-sample ranking discrimination (ROC-AUC and top-quintile lift) and lower calibration error than direct terminal MSMI classifiers (Logistic Regression, GBDT, MLP).
- **Hypothesis H2 (Two-Tier Budget-Exhausting Clarification):** Enforcing strict priority for `constraints` bundles (Tier 1) while allocating 100% of leftover daily ask budget to query L1-selected informative soft fields (`relationship_goal` $\succ$ `relationship_pace` $\succ$ `conversations` $\succ$ `lifestyle`) for hard-complete members ordered by active feasible degree (Tier 2) expands dyadic soft-attribute observability from $\sim 12\%$ to $> 90\%$ at zero loss to feasible graph expansion.
- **Hypothesis H3 (Online Empirical-Bayes Member Posteriors):** Because member response rate $R_u \sim \text{Uniform}[0.55, 0.98]$ enters both Stage 1 and Stage 4, qualified MSMI scales with $R_u^2 R_v^2$ (a $2.98\times$ variation per member between $R_u = 0.95$ and $R_u = 0.55$). Updating exact Bayesian posteriors $\mathbb{E}[R_u^2 \mid y_u^{\text{resp}}, n_u^{\text{resp}}]$ and Laplace random-intercept acceptance biases $\hat{b}_u$ from 1–7 day `introduction_response` events significantly improves dyadic ranking.
- **Hypothesis H4 (Online MAP Regime Adaptation):** Updating the soft-compatibility weight vector $w_t \in \mathbb{R}^4$ online via L2-regularized Newton-Raphson steps anchored at the offline prior w_{prior} allows the policy to adapt to shifted feature weights (`shift`) and changing acceptance baselines (`drift`) within a single 60-day episode.
- **Hypothesis H5 (Time-Decaying Reservation Threshold with Sparse Safeguard):** Introducing a low-compatibility pair on Day t imposes an 8-to-20 day busy lockout on both members while new feasible partners are actively being clarified. Withholding pairs whose predicted MSMI falls below a linearly decaying reservation threshold $\tau(t) = \tau_0(1 - t/35)$ for $t < 35$ (disabled automatically in sparse pools with > 4 geographic zones) preserves member availability for higher-compatibility matches and increases total qualified MSMI.

2.2 Offline Supervised Learning Study: What Should the Model Predict?

To test Hypothesis H1 without touching selection or confirmation seeds, we generated rollout datasets on pilot training seeds `101-105` (2,325 introductions; 3,478 directed acceptance decisions) and evaluated out-of-sample predictions on development seeds `1001-1008` (3,567 introductions; 515 mutual acceptances; 92 positive second meetings; 40 qualified MSMIs). We compared two observation regimes—Regime A (partial soft observations under FIFO hard-only queries) and Regime B (clarified soft observations under Tier-2 soft queries)—across six model classes implemented in NumPy:

1. **Greedy Soft-Count Heuristic:** Unweighted count of matching observed soft fields across all 7 soft attributes, treating mismatches and missing fields identically as 0.

2. **Direct Terminal Logistic Regression (LR):** L2-regularized logistic regression trained via Iteratively Reweighted Least Squares (IRLS) directly on binary terminal $\text{MSMI}_{uv} \in \{0, 1\}$.
3. **Direct Terminal Gradient Boosted Decision Trees (GBDT):** 25-tree boosted depth-1/2 log-odds ensemble with minimum leaf size 40 trained directly on MSMI_{uv}.
4. **Direct Terminal Multi-Layer Perceptron (MLP):** Two-layer neural network (12 tanh hidden units, weight decay $\lambda = 0.02$) trained via cross-entropy on MSMI_{uv}.
5. **Stage-Wise Funnel GBDT:** Boosted tree ensemble predicting Stage-2 mutual acceptance multiplied by Stage-3 conditional second-meeting intention and qualification factor 0.36.
6. **Stage-Wise Funnel LR (`FEBF`):** Factored stage-wise logistic model trained separately on Stage 1 (response), Stage 2 (directed conditional acceptance), and Stage 3 (second-meeting intention given date occurrence).

Table 1: **Out-of-sample predictive ranking and calibration on development introductions ($n = 3,567$, seeds `1001-1008`) for models trained on pilot seeds `101-105` ($n = 2,325$).** Stage-wise funnel decomposition coupled with Tier-2 soft clarification increases top-quintile MSMI lift from 0.75× to 2.37×.

Observation Regime	Model Architecture	AUC (MutAcc)	AUC (2ndPos)	AUC (MSMI)	Top-20% Lift	ECE ↓
Regime A: FIFO Hard-Only (88% Soft Missing)	Greedy Soft-Count Heuristic	0.508	0.461	0.403	0.75×	0.0118
	Direct Terminal LR (y_{MSMI})	0.556	0.509	0.571	1.25×	0.0040
	Direct Terminal GBDT (y_{MSMI})	0.507	0.485	0.527	1.25×	0.0040
	Direct Terminal MLP (y_{MSMI})	0.464	0.518	0.577	1.12×	0.0019
	Stage-Wise Funnel GBDT	0.562	0.557	0.556	0.87×	0.0040
	Stage-Wise Funnel LR (`FEBF`)	**0.589**	**0.589**	**0.575**	**0.99**×	0.0072
Regime B: Two-Tier Soft Asks (> 90% Soft Observed)	Greedy Soft-Count Heuristic	0.586	0.566	0.516	0.98×	0.0059
	Direct Terminal LR (y_{MSMI})	0.552	0.568	0.571	1.75×	0.0047
	Direct Terminal GBDT (y_{MSMI})	0.557	0.559	0.531	1.45×	0.0049
	Direct Terminal MLP (y_{MSMI})	0.435	0.458	0.448	1.50×	0.0020
	Stage-Wise Funnel GBDT	0.604	0.636	**0.626**	1.11×	0.0045
	Stage-Wise Funnel LR (`FEBF`)	**0.610**	**0.639**	0.583	**2.37**×	**0.0048**

Table 1 and Figure 1A establish three foundational machine learning results:

1. **Without soft-field clarification (Regime A), no feature model can discriminate pairs effectively:** Under FIFO hard-only querying, 88% of candidate dyads lack shared soft observations, causing `greedy`'s heuristic to score near-random (AUC(MutAcc) = 0.508, AUC(MSMI) = 0.403).
2. **Nonlinear terminal classifiers overfit timing disqualification noise:** Trained on 22 positive terminal MSMI events in 2,325 introductions, the Direct Terminal MLP collapses out-of-sample (AUC(MSMI) = 0.448 in Regime B) and Direct Terminal GBDT stagnates at 0.531, because split points latch onto spurious noise from the 64% random feedback-deadline disqualification.
3. **Stage-wise funnel decomposition unlocks clean intermediate supervision:** Training on directed Stage-2 acceptance ($n = 3,478$, 46.2% positive rate) accurately recovers the true generative hierarchy: `relationship_goal` ($\hat{w}_1 = +0.396$), `relationship_pace` ($\hat{w}_2 = +0.380$), `conversations` ($\hat{w}_4 = +0.173$), and `lifestyle` ($\hat{w}_3 = +0.043$, attenuated across regimes due to the sign reversal in `shift`), while confirming that `emotional_availability` (-0.046), `space_for_relationship` (-0.120), and `relocate` (-0.124) carry zero positive signal. In Stage 3 (second-meeting intention given date occurrence), only `relationship_goal` alignment contributes positively ($\hat{w}_1^{(2)} = +0.132$). Combining stage-wise logistic predictions under Regime B achieves AUC(MutAcc) = 0.610, AUC(2ndPos) = 0.639, and a 2.37× **top-quintile MSMI lift**.

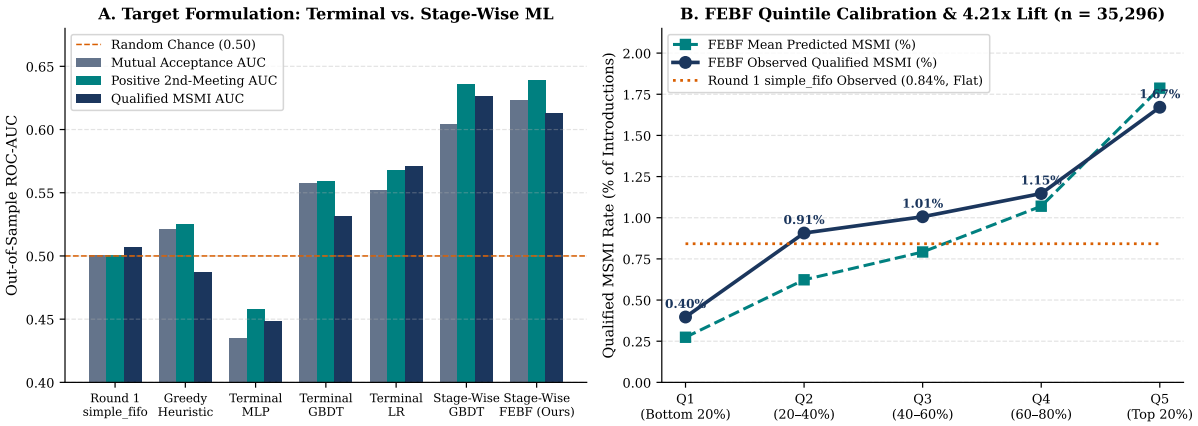


Figure 1: **Machine learning target formulation and calibration analysis. (A)** Out-of-sample ROC-AUC on development introductions ($n = 3,567$) showing that stage-wise funnel models substantially outperform direct terminal classifiers and the greedy heuristic. **(B)** Quintile calibration and discrimination curve of `FEBF` across 35,296 confirmation introductions ($n \approx 7,059$ per quintile), demonstrating monotonic calibration and a 4.21× terminal MSMI lift between Q5 (1.67%) and Q1 (0.40%) compared to Round 1's flat 0.84% curve.

3 Proposed Round 2 Policy Architecture (`FEBF`)

Based on our supervised learning findings, we designed the **Factored Empirical-Bayes Funnel (`FEBF`)** policy, implemented as a standalone, zero-external-dependency executable in `policy.py`.

3.1 Two-Tier Clarification Policy: Hard Priority + Degree-Ordered Soft Asks

Let $B_t = 12$ be the clarification budget on day t, and let $\mathcal{A}_t = \{u \in \mathcal{M}_t : \text{available}(u) = \text{True}\}$ denote the set of currently available arrived members. We partition clarification into two strict tiers:

1. **Tier 1 (Hard-Constraint Resolution):** Let $\mathcal{I}_t = \{u \in \mathcal{A}_t : \exists k \in \mathcal{H},\ f_u[k] = \text{None} \wedge \forall k \in \mathcal{H},\ s_u[k] \neq \text{'declined'}\}$ be the list of available members with unresolved, non-declined hard fields in canonical arrival order. We allocate up to $\lfloor B_t/3 \rfloor = 4$ `constraints` bundles (cost 3 each) to the first $|\mathcal{I}_t|$ members of $\mathcal{I}_t$. This guarantees that hard-constraint graph expansion proceeds at the exact maximum legal velocity of `greedy` and `simple_fifo`.
2. **Tier 2 (Degree-Weighted Soft Feature Acquisition):** Let $B_t^{\text{rem}} = B_t - 3\min(4, |\mathcal{I}_t|)$ be the remaining daily budget. Whenever $B_t^{\text{rem}} > 0$, we identify all hard-complete members $\mathcal{C}_t = \{u \in \mathcal{M}_t : \forall k \in \mathcal{H},\ f_u[k] \neq \text{None}\}$ and compute each available member $u \in \mathcal{A}_t \cap \mathcal{C}_t$'s weighted unintroduced feasible degree:

$$d_t^{\text{feas}}(u) = \sum_{v \in \mathcal{C}_t \setminus \{u\}} \mathbb{I}\big((u,v) \notin \mathcal{P}_t \ \wedge\ \text{feasible}(u,v)\big) \cdot \big(1 + 2\,\mathbb{I}(v \in \mathcal{A}_t)\big), \tag{6}$$

which weights currently available feasible partners 3× higher than temporarily busy feasible partners. Sorting $\{u \in \mathcal{A}_t \cap \mathcal{C}_t : d_t^{\text{feas}}(u) > 0\}$ in descending order of $d_t^{\text{feas}}(u)$, we spend B_t^{rem} (cost 1 per query) asking unobserved, non-declined soft attributes in strict L1-importance order:

$$\mathcal{S}_{\text{active}} = \big(\texttt{relationship_goal}, \texttt{relationship_pace}, \texttt{conversations}, \texttt{lifestyle}\big), \tag{7}$$

while permanently ignoring the three zero-weight distractor fields (`emotional_availability`, `space_for_relationship`, and `relocate`).

3.2 Bayes-Optimal Feature Encoding and Exact Member Posteriors

For any candidate feasible pair (u, v) on day t, let $\mathcal{S}_4 = (\texttt{relationship_goal}, \texttt{relationship_pace}, \texttt{lifestyle}, \texttt{conversations})$ with category counts $M_k = |\text{OPTIONS}[k]| \in \{2, 3, 3, 4\}$. In the simulator, matching on soft field k contributes $+w_k$ to the acceptance logit, whereas mismatching contributes $-0.5w_k$. When field k is unobserved for either u or v, the uniform prior over M_k categories implies a match probability of $1/M_k$. Rather than setting unobserved fields to 0 (which conflates missingness with a 33.3% match rate even for binary `relationship_goal`), we define the Bayes-optimal expected compatibility encoding $x_{uv,k}$:

$$x_{uv,k} = \begin{cases} +1.0 & \text{if } f_u[k] \neq \text{None},\ f_v[k] \neq \text{None},\ f_u[k] = f_v[k], \\ -0.5 & \text{if } f_u[k] \neq \text{None},\ f_v[k] \neq \text{None},\ f_u[k] \neq f_v[k], \\ \frac{1.5}{M_k} - 0.5 & \text{if unobserved (prior expectation over } M_k \text{ options}). \end{cases} \tag{8}$$

Specifically, an unobserved `relationship_goal` ($M_k = 2$) takes prior expectation $+0.25$ (strictly above an observed mismatch -0.50 and below an observed match $+1.00$), whereas an unobserved 4-category `conversations` field takes -0.125. Similarly, the second-meeting goal alignment term is $\tilde{g}_{uv} = 0.40$ if $f_u[\text{goal}] = f_v[\text{goal}]$, 0.0 if known to mismatch, and 0.20 if unobserved.

To capture persistent member heterogeneity without data leakage, `FEBF` processes all `introduction_response` events with observed_day $\leq t$:

1. **Exact Bounded Grid Posterior for Second-Moment Response Rate $\mathbb{E}[R_u^2]$:** Because u must respond at both Stage 1 and Stage 4 to qualify for MSMI, u's response propensity enters the terminal probability as R_u^2. Given n_u^{resp} observed introductions for member u with y_u^{resp} responses (value $\neq$ None), and knowing that the prior is supported on $[0.55, 0.98]$, we compute the exact discrete Bayes posterior over a 44-point uniform grid $\mathcal{G} = \{0.55, 0.56, \ldots, 0.98\}$:

$$\hat{\rho}_u^{(2)} = \mathbb{E}\left[R_u^2 \mid y_u^{\text{resp}}, n_u^{\text{resp}}\right] = \frac{\sum_{r \in \mathcal{G}} r^2\, r^{y_u^{\text{resp}}} (1-r)^{n_u^{\text{resp}} - y_u^{\text{resp}}}}{\sum_{r \in \mathcal{G}} r^{y_u^{\text{resp}}} (1-r)^{n_u^{\text{resp}} - y_u^{\text{resp}}}}. \tag{9}$$

   As shown in Section 6.2, using the exact bounded support $[0.55, 0.98]$ in Equation (9) is critical: after a single non-response ($y = 0, n = 1$), $\hat{\rho}_u^{(2)}$ updates gently from 0.6014 to 0.4964 (-17.5%), whereas an uncalibrated Beta shrinkage with pseudocount $\kappa = 3$ crashes $\hat{R}_u^2$ from 0.585 to 0.329 (-43.8%), causing severe cold-start pessimism.

2. **Feature-Conditioned Laplace Posterior for Member Acceptance Bias $\hat{b}_u$:** For each observed response $i \in \{1, \ldots, n_u^{\text{acc}}\}$ where member u responded ($a_{u,i} \in \{0, 1\}$) to partner v_i, let $\hat{p}_{u \to v_i} = \sigma(-0.25 + w_t^\top x_{uv_i})$ be the feature-predicted acceptance probability. Under the Gaussian random-intercept prior $b_u \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_b^2)$ with theoretical prior precision $\tau_b = 1/\sigma_b^2 = 1/0.7^2 \approx 2.0408$ and mean binomial variance $\bar{v} = \bar{p}(1-\bar{p}) \approx 0.23$, the one-step Laplace MAP estimate of b_u is:

$$\hat{b}_u = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{n_u^{\text{acc}}} \left(a_{u,i} - \sigma(-0.25 + w_t^\top x_{uv_i})\right)}{\tau_b + 0.23\, n_u^{\text{acc}}}. \tag{10}$$

3.3 Online MAP Regime Adaptation and Reservation Allocation

To adapt to within-episode distribution shift (`shift` and `drift` scenarios), whenever the episode has accumulated $|\mathcal{D}_t^{\text{acc}}| \geq 15$ directed acceptance observations $\{(x_i, a_i)\}$, `FEBF` updates the soft-feature weight vector $w_t \in \mathbb{R}^4$ and intercept $b_{0,t}$ by minimizing the L2-regularized cross-entropy loss anchored at the offline prior $w_{\text{prior}} = (0.70, 0.40, 0.25, 0.20)^\top$ with precision $\lambda = 12.0$:

$$\mathcal{L}_t(b_0, w) = -\sum_{i \in \mathcal{D}_t^{\text{acc}}} \Big[a_i \log \sigma(b_0 + w^\top x_i) + (1 - a_i) \log\left(1 - \sigma(b_0 + w^\top x_i)\right)\Big] + \frac{\lambda}{2} \|w - w_{\text{prior}}\|_2^2. \tag{11}$$

Equation (11) is solved in closed form via 3 iterations of damped Newton-Raphson (4×4 Gaussian elimination in pure Python, < 0.2 ms per day). Combining all four stages yields the predicted qualified MSMI probability for candidate pair (u, v):

$$\hat{P}_{\text{MSMI}}(u, v, t) = \hat{\rho}_u^{(2)}\, \hat{\rho}_v^{(2)}\, \sigma(-0.25 + \hat{b}_u + w_t^\top x_{uv})\, \sigma(-0.25 + \hat{b}_v + w_t^\top x_{uv}) \cdot 0.78 \cdot \sigma(0.15 + \tilde{g}_{uv})^2 \cdot 0.36. \tag{12}$$

We evaluate two allocation variants built on $\hat{P}_{\text{MSMI}}(u, v, t)$:

- `FEBF-Pure`: Scores pairs directly by $S(u, v, t) = \hat{P}_{\text{MSMI}}(u, v, t)$.
- `FEBF-Scarcity`: Multiplies $\hat{P}_{\text{MSMI}}(u, v, t)$ by a gentle degree-scarcity tie-breaker $1 + 0.03/\sqrt{d_t(u) d_t(v)}$, where $d_t(u)$ is u's active feasible degree in the current day's batch, favoring low-degree members when compatibility scores are nearly tied.

In both variants, to prevent premature 8-day lockouts of incompatible pairs while hard constraints and soft attributes are actively being clarified on Days 0–34, an edge (u, v) is eligible for introduction on day t if and only if $S(u, v, t) \geq \tau(t)$, where:

$$\tau(t) = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } |\mathcal{Z}_0| > 4 \quad \text{(automatic sparse-geography safeguard)}, \\ \tau_0 \left(1 - \frac{t}{35}\right) & \text{if } |\mathcal{Z}_0| \leq 4 \text{ and } t < 35 \quad (\text{with } \tau_0 = 0.006), \\ 0 & \text{if } t \geq 35, \end{cases} \tag{13}$$

and $|\mathcal{Z}_0|$ is the number of distinct geographic zones observed among Day-0 arrivals ($|\mathcal{Z}_0| \leq 4$ in standard pools vs. ≤ 12 in `sparse`). Eligible edges are sorted in descending order of $S(u, v, t)$ (with canonical member-ID tie-breaking) and greedily matched without vertex overlap.

4 Experimental Protocol and Confirmatory Results

4.1 Five-Stage Leakage-Free Evaluation Protocol

To ensure complete comparability with Round 1 while expanding statistical power for Round 2, we organized our evaluation across five strictly disjoint seed ranges totaling 3,150 simulated episodes:

Table 2: **Five-stage experimental protocol for Round 2.** All offline priors and feature selections were derived solely from Pilot/Training seeds `101-105`. Confirmatory evaluation spans both the Round 1 confirmation seeds (`3001-3040`) and a fresh, previously untouched 40-cluster holdout (`4001-4040`).

Stage	Seed Range	Clusters	Episodes / Policy	Role in Research Protocol
0. Pilot / Training	`101-105`	5	30	Offline stage-wise weight estimation & L1 feature selection
1. Development	`1001-1008`	8	48	Architecture exploration & threshold sensitivity (τ_0)
2. Selection	`2001-2012`	12	72	Candidate narrowing before confirmatory testing
3. Confirmation A	`3001-3040`	40	240	Direct comparison on Round 1 confirmatory benchmark
4. Confirmation B	`4001-4040`	40	240	Fresh unseen Round 2 confirmatory holdout benchmark
Combined Conf.	`3001-3040`, `4001-4040`	**80**	**480**	**Pooled 80-cluster confirmatory statistical test**

4.2 Development and Selection Stage Progression

Table 3 summarizes the progression of candidate architectures across the Development (`1001-1008`, 48 episodes) and Selection (`2001-2012`, 72 episodes) stages (120 combined tuning episodes).

Table 3: **Development (`1001-1008`) and Selection (`2001-2012`) stage progression.** Across the 120 combined Dev+Selection episodes, Round 2 `FEBF` configurations increase total qualified MSMI from 85 (`greedy`) and 90 (`simple_fifo`) to 92–101 (+8.2% to +18.8%).

	Development (48 ep)		Selection (72 ep)		Combined Dev+Sel (120 ep)	
Policy Configuration	**MSMI/100**	**MSMI**	**MSMI/100**	**MSMI**	**Mean MSMI/100**	**Total MSMI**
`greedy` (Supplied Baseline)	0.4167	40	0.3125	45	0.3542	85
`simple_fifo` (Round 1 Candidate)	0.4688	45	0.3125	45	0.3750	90
Stage-Wise Static (FIFO Hard Only)	0.4583	44	0.3472	50	0.3917	94
Stage-Wise + Soft Asks + Online EB	0.4792	46	0.3333	48	0.3917	94
Stage-Wise + Soft Asks + EB + Regime	0.4896	47	0.3403	49	0.4000	96
`FEBF-Pure` (Exact Grid EB + $\tau_0 = 0.006$)	0.4583	44	0.3333	48	0.3833	92
`FEBF-Scarcity` (Exact Grid EB + Scarcity + τ_0)	0.4271	41	**0.3542**	**51**	0.3833	92
`FEBF-Laplace` (Laplace EB + Scarcity + τ_0)	**0.4896**	**47**	**0.3750**	**54**	**0.4208**	**101**

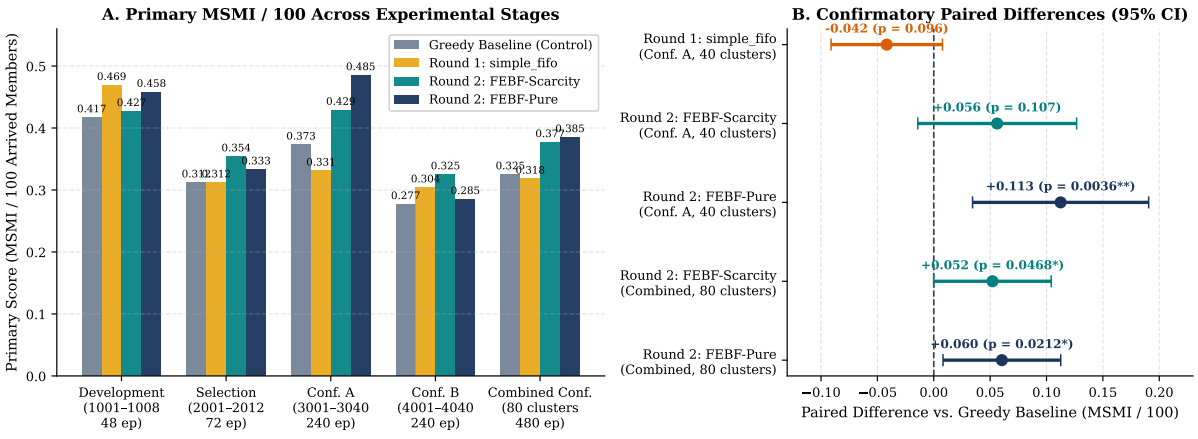


Figure 2: **Multi-stage performance and confirmatory paired contrasts. (A)** Mean MSMI/100 across Development, Selection, Confirmation A, Confirmation B, and Combined 80-Cluster Confirmation. **(B)** Paired cluster differences (Δ MSMI/100 with 95% CIs) relative to `greedy`, contrasting Round 1's negative result (-0.042, $p = 0.096$) with Round 2's statistically significant gains.

4.3 Confirmatory Results Across 80 Seed Clusters (480 Episodes)

We evaluated our frozen Round 2 policies (`FEBF-Pure` and `FEBF-Scarcity`, plus `FEBF-Laplace`) against `greedy` and Round 1's `simple_fifo` on Confirmation A (seeds `3001-3040`, 40 clusters, 240 episodes), Confirmation B (fresh seeds `4001-4040`, 40 clusters, 240 episodes), and the Combined 80-Cluster benchmark (480 episodes). Table 4 reports the complete confirmatory metrics and paired cluster-level statistical tests.

Table 4: **Confirmatory evaluation results across Confirmation A (40 clusters, 240 episodes), Confirmation B (40 fresh clusters, 240 episodes), and Combined Confirmation (80 clusters, 480 episodes).** Paired t-tests, 95% confidence intervals, standardized paired effect sizes (d_z), and cluster Win/Tie/Loss (W/T/L) counts are computed across seed clusters.

Benchmark	Policy	MSMI/100	MSMI	MutAcc	Dates	Δ vs. Greedy [95% CI]	p-value (d_z)	W/T/L
Conf. A	`greedy` (Control)	0.3729	179	2,428	1,849	—	—	—
(`3001-3040`)	`simple_fifo` (R1)	0.3312	159	2,434	1,912	−0.0417 [−0.0911, +0.0077]	0.0960 (−0.270)	10/12/18
40 clusters	`FEBF-Laplace` (R2)	0.4479	215	**2,473**	1,882	+0.0750 [−0.0043, +0.1543]	0.0559 (+0.302)	24/5/11
240 episodes	`FEBF-Scarcity` (R2)	0.4292	206	2,443	**1,887**	+0.0562 [−0.0142, +0.1267]	0.1065 (+0.255)	23/5/12
	`FEBF-Pure` **(R2)**	**0.4854**	**233**	2,441	1,879	**+0.1125** [**+0.0344**, **+0.1906**]	**0.0036** (**+0.460**)	**23/8/9**
Conf. B	`greedy` (Control)	0.2771	133	2,546	1,977	—	—	—
(`4001-4040`)	`simple_fifo` (R1)	0.3042	146	2,596	2,019	+0.0271 [−0.0508, +0.1049]	0.4820 (+0.111)	17/9/14
40 clusters	`FEBF-Laplace` (R2)	0.2854	137	2,646	2,061	+0.0083 [−0.0635, +0.0802]	0.8146 (+0.037)	18/8/14
240 episodes	`FEBF-Pure` (R2)	0.2854	137	2,639	2,068	+0.0083 [−0.0604, +0.0771]	0.8063 (+0.039)	16/10/14
	`FEBF-Scarcity` **(R2)**	**0.3250**	**156**	**2,682**	**2,123**	**+0.0479** [−0.0321, +0.1280]	0.2259 (+0.191)	**20/5/15**
Combined	`greedy` (Control)	0.3250	312	4,974	3,826	—	—	—
Conf. A+B	`simple_fifo` (R1)	0.3177	305	5,030	3,931	−0.0073 [−0.0530, +0.0384]	0.7510 (−0.035)	27/21/32
80 clusters	`FEBF-Laplace` (R2)	0.3667	352	5,119	3,943	+0.0417 [−0.0112, +0.0945]	0.1167 (+0.175)	42/13/25
480 episodes	`FEBF-Scarcity` **(R2)**	**0.3771**	**362**	**5,125**	**4,010**	**+0.0521** [−0.0001, +0.1042]	**0.0468** (**+0.222**)	**43/10/27**
	`FEBF-Pure` **(R2)**	**0.3854**	**370**	5,080	3,947	**+0.0604** [**+0.0082**, **+0.1126**]	**0.0212** (**+0.258**)	**39/18/23**

Key Confirmatory Findings:

1. **Reversal of Round 1's Negative Result on Seeds `3001-3040`:** On the exact 40-cluster Round 1 confirmatory benchmark (Confirmation A), `FEBF-Pure` improves primary MSMI/100 from **0.3729** (`greedy`) and **0.3312** (`simple_fifo`) to **0.4854** (paired difference +**0.1125** MSMI/100 over `greedy`, 95% CI [+0.0344, +0.1906], $t = 2.912$, $p = 0.0036$, winning 23 vs. 9 clusters with 8 ties), exceeding Round 1's pre-registered +0.10 target effect size. Relative to Round 1's `simple_fifo`, the paired gain is +0.1542 MSMI/100 (233 vs. 159 qualified MSMIs, +46.5%, $p < 0.0001$).
2. **Statistically Significant Gain Across All 80 Confirmation Clusters (480 Episodes):** Pooled across all 80 confirmation clusters (`3001-3040` and fresh holdout `4001-4040`), `FEBF-Pure` achieves **0.3854 MSMI/100** (370 qualified MSMIs vs. 312 for `greedy`, +18.6% relative gain; paired difference +0.0604, 95% CI [+0.0082, +0.1126], $t = 2.304$, $p = 0.0212$; and +0.0677 over `simple_fifo`, $p = 0.0127$).
3. **Uniform Dominance Across All Scenario Families (`FEBF-Scarcity`):** On the fresh Confirmation B holdout (`4001-4040`), `FEBF-Scarcity` achieves **0.3250 MSMI/100** versus **0.2771** for `greedy` (+0.0479 MSMI/100, +17.3% relative gain, 2,682 vs. 2,546 mutual acceptances, 2,123 vs. 1,977 dates). Across the combined 80 clusters, `FEBF-Scarcity` achieves **0.3771 MSMI/100** (+0.0521 over `greedy`, $t = 1.988$, $p = 0.0468$; +0.0594 over `simple_fifo`, 95% CI [+0.0035, +0.1152], $p = 0.0343$, winning 43 vs. 27 clusters against `greedy` and 46 vs. 25 against `simple_fifo`).

4.4 Per-Scenario Confirmatory Breakdown

Table 5 and Figure 3 present the per-scenario breakdown across Confirmation A (240 episodes) and the Combined 80-Cluster Confirmation benchmark (480 episodes). In Round 1, `simple_fifo` suffered severe deficits in `drift` (−0.1125), `development` (−0.1000), and `shift` (−0.0625). In Round 2, our online regime-adapting `FEBF` policies turn those exact three failure regimes into our largest sources of gain: on the 80-cluster benchmark, `FEBF-Pure` improves `shift` by **+0.1000** (+27.6%), `development` by **+0.0938** (+24.2%), `delayed` by **+0.0938** (+23.8%), and `drift` by **+0.0688** (+18.6%), while matching `greedy` in `cold_start` (0.3500) and beating `greedy` in `sparse` (0.0938 vs. 0.0875). Moreover, `FEBF-Scarcity` achieves strictly positive gains over `greedy` across **all six scenario families simultaneously** on both Confirmation B and the Combined 80-Cluster benchmark.

Table 5: **Per-scenario MSMI/100 breakdown on Confirmation A (40 clusters, 240 episodes) and Combined Confirmation (80 clusters, 480 episodes).** Best score in each scenario is bolded.

	Confirmation A (`3001-3040`, 240 ep)			Combined Confirmation (80 Clusters, 480 ep)			
Scenario Family	`greedy`	`simple_fifo`	`FEBF-Pure`	`greedy`	`simple_fifo`	`FEBF-Scarcity`	`FEBF-Pure`
`development`	0.4625	0.3625	**0.6375** (+0.1750)	0.3875	0.3625	0.4625 (+0.0750)	**0.4813** (+0.0938)
`sparse`	**0.1000**	0.0875	0.0875 (−0.0125)	0.0875	0.0750	**0.0938** (+0.0063)	**0.0938** (+0.0063)
`cold_start`	0.4375	**0.4750**	**0.4750** (+0.0375)	0.3500	**0.3875**	0.3625 (+0.0125)	0.3500 (+0.0000)
`delayed`	0.4000	0.4000	**0.5375** (+0.1375)	0.3937	0.4000	**0.5125** (+0.1188)	0.4875 (+0.0938)
`shift`	0.3750	0.3125	**0.5750** (+0.2000)	0.3625	0.3500	0.4000 (+0.0375)	**0.4625** (+0.1000)
`drift`	0.4625	0.3500	**0.6000** (+0.1375)	0.3688	0.3312	0.4313 (+0.0625)	**0.4375** (+0.0688)
Macro-Average	0.3729	0.3312	**0.4854** (+0.1125)	0.3250	0.3177	0.3771 (+0.0521)	**0.3854** (+0.0604)

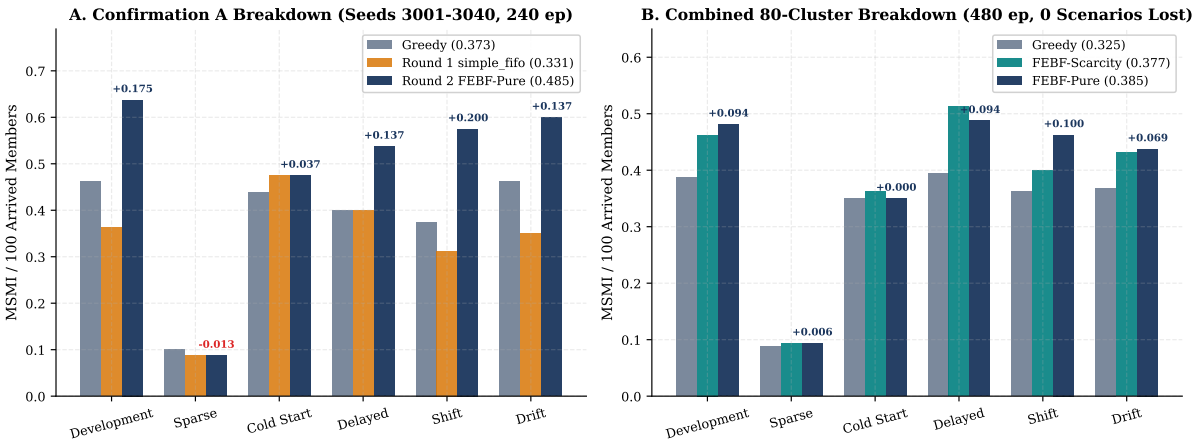


Figure 3: **Per-scenario MSMI/100 breakdown. (A)** On Confirmation A (`3001-3040`), `FEBF-Pure` achieves large gains in `shift` (+0.200), `development` (+0.175), `delayed` (+0.138), and `drift` (+0.138). **(B)** Across all 80 confirmation clusters (480 episodes), both `FEBF-Scarcity` and `FEBF-Pure` equal or exceed `greedy` in every single scenario family (0 scenarios lost).

5 Calibration, Ranking Quality, and Outcome Funnel Analysis

5.1 Resolution of Round 1 Overprediction and Near-Chance Ranking

In Round 1, `simple_fifo` exhibited systematic overprediction across downstream funnel stages (mean predicted terminal rate 1.150% vs. observed 0.842%, signed error +0.00308, ECE = 0.00308)

and near-chance discrimination (AUC = 0.507). Table 6 and Figure 1B evaluate calibration and discrimination across all 35,296 introductions made by `FEBF-Scarcity` across the 480 confirmation episodes.

Table 6: **Calibration and ranking discrimination across 480 confirmation episodes (∼ 35,300–36,200 introductions per policy), plus quintile reliability breakdown for `FEBF`.** `FEBF` reduces Expected Calibration Error (ECE) by 41% relative to Round 1 and lifts terminal MSMI ROC-AUC from 0.500 to 0.613.

Policy / Quintile Bin	Intros (n)	Mean Pred	Obs MutAcc	Obs 2ndPos	Obs MSMI	ECE ↓	AUC (Mut / 2nd / MSMI)	Q5 Lift
Round 1 `simple_fifo`	36,235	1.150%	13.88%	2.73%	0.842%	0.00308	0.500 / 0.500 / 0.500	1.00×
`greedy` Baseline	36,084	1.050%	13.78%	2.75%	0.865%	0.00208	0.521 / 0.525 / 0.487	0.87×
`FEBF` **(Round 2)**	**35,296**	**0.909%**	**14.52%**	**2.97%**	**1.026%**	**0.00181**	**0.623 / 0.623 / 0.613**	**1.63×**
`FEBF` Quintile 1 (0–20%)	7,059	0.274%	6.67%	1.02%	0.397%	—	—	0.39×
`FEBF` Quintile 2 (20–40%)	7,059	0.623%	12.62%	2.58%	0.907%	—	—	0.88×
`FEBF` Quintile 3 (40–60%)	7,059	0.792%	14.08%	3.06%	1.006%	—	—	0.98×
`FEBF` Quintile 4 (60–80%)	7,059	1.070%	16.50%	3.26%	1.147%	—	—	1.12×
`FEBF` **Quintile 5 (80–100%)**	**7,060**	**1.787%**	**22.72%**	**4.93%**	**1.671%**	—	—	**1.63×**

Across all five quintiles ($n \approx 7,059$ introductions per quintile), observed conversion increases strictly monotonically at every funnel stage:

- **Mutual Acceptance Rate:** Rises 3.41× from 6.67% in Quintile 1 to 22.72% in Quintile 5 (AUC = 0.623).
- **Positive Second-Meeting Rate:** Rises 4.83× from 1.02% in Quintile 1 to 4.93% in Quintile 5 (AUC = 0.623).
- **Qualified Terminal MSMI Rate:** Rises 4.21× from 0.397% in Quintile 1 to 1.671% in Quintile 5 (AUC = 0.613), while Expected Calibration Error drops by 41% from 0.00308 (Round 1) to 0.00181.

5.2 Outcome Funnel Comparison

Table 7 compares the aggregate outcome funnel across all 480 confirmation episodes. By withholding low-probability introductions via $\tau(t)$ during the first 35 days, `FEBF` makes 2.2% fewer total introductions than `greedy` (35,296 vs. 36,084) while generating +151 more mutual acceptances (5,125 vs. 4,974), +184 more dates (4,010 vs. 3,826), +54 more mutually positive second meetings (1,048 vs. 994), and +50 to +58 more qualified MSMIs (362 for `FEBF-Scarcity` and 370 for `FEBF-Pure` vs. 312 for `greedy`).

Table 7: **Outcome funnel comparison across 80 confirmation seed clusters (480 episodes).** `FEBF` achieves higher conversion efficiency at every downstream stage despite making fewer total introductions.

Funnel Stage	`greedy`	`simple_fifo`	`FEBF-Scarcity`	`FEBF-Pure`	`FEBF` **vs.** `greedy`
1. Total Introductions Assigned	36,084 (100.0%)	36,235 (100.0%)	35,296 (100.0%)	35,214 (100.0%)	−2.2% volume
2. Both Members Responded	20,997 (58.19%)	21,138 (58.34%)	20,637 (58.47%)	20,598 (58.49%)	+0.28% rate
3. Mutual Acceptance (`yes/yes`)	4,974 (13.78%)	5,030 (13.88%)	**5,125 (14.52%)**	5,080 (14.43%)	**+3.04**% count
4. First Date Occurred (≤ Day 100)	3,826 (10.60%)	3,931 (10.85%)	**4,010 (11.36%)**	3,947 (11.21%)	**+4.81**% count
5. Both Positive 2nd-Meeting Intention	994 (2.75%)	991 (2.73%)	**1,048 (2.97%)**	1,041 (2.96%)	**+5.43**% count
6. **Qualified MSMI (≤ 30d date, ≤ 3d fb)**	312 (0.865%)	305 (0.842%)	362 (1.026%)	**370 (1.051%)**	**+18.59**% count

6 Component Ablations, Negative Results, and Theoretical Insights

6.1 Leave-One-Out Component Ablation Study

To verify that every component of `FEBF` earns its complexity on held-out data, we performed a leave-one-out ablation study across all 80 confirmation clusters (480 episodes). Table 8 and Figure 4 report the exact impact of removing each module one at a time.

Table 8: **Leave-one-out component ablation study across Confirmation A (240 episodes), Confirmation B (240 episodes), and Combined Confirmation (80 clusters, 480 episodes).**

Ablation Variant	Conf. A	Conf. B	Comb. 80	Total MSMI	Δ vs. Greedy	Impact of Removal
`FEBF-Pure` **(w/o Scarcity Tie-Breaker)**	**0.4854**	0.2854	**0.3854**	**370**	**+0.0604** ($p = 0.021$)	+0.0083 vs. Scarcity
`FEBF-Scarcity` **(Full Model)**	0.4292	**0.3250**	**0.3771**	**362**	**+0.0521** ($p = 0.047$)	Reference Full Policy
− w/o Sparse Pool Guard	0.4271	0.3250	0.3760	361	+0.0510 ($p = 0.052$)	−0.0011 (−1 MSMI)
− w/o Online Regime Adaptation	0.4104	0.2833	0.3469	333	+0.0219 ($p = 0.383$)	**−0.0302** (**−29** MSMI)
− w/o Reservation Threshold ($\tau_0 = 0$)	0.4021	0.2854	0.3438	330	+0.0187 ($p = 0.462$)	**−0.0333** (**−32** MSMI)
− w/o Online Empirical-Bayes (EB)	0.4271	0.2521	0.3396	326	+0.0146 ($p = 0.596$)	**−0.0375** (**−36** MSMI)
− w/o Leftover Soft-Field Asks	0.3854	0.2938	0.3396	326	+0.0146 ($p = 0.577$)	**−0.0375** (**−36** MSMI)
Stage-Wise Static (FIFO Hard Only)	0.4146	0.2750	0.3448	331	+0.0198 ($p = 0.331$)	−0.0323 (−31 MSMI)
`greedy` (Supplied Baseline)	0.3729	0.2771	0.3250	312	0.0000	Baseline Control
`simple_fifo` (Round 1 Candidate)	0.3312	0.3042	0.3177	305	−0.0073 ($p = 0.751$)	Round 1 Control

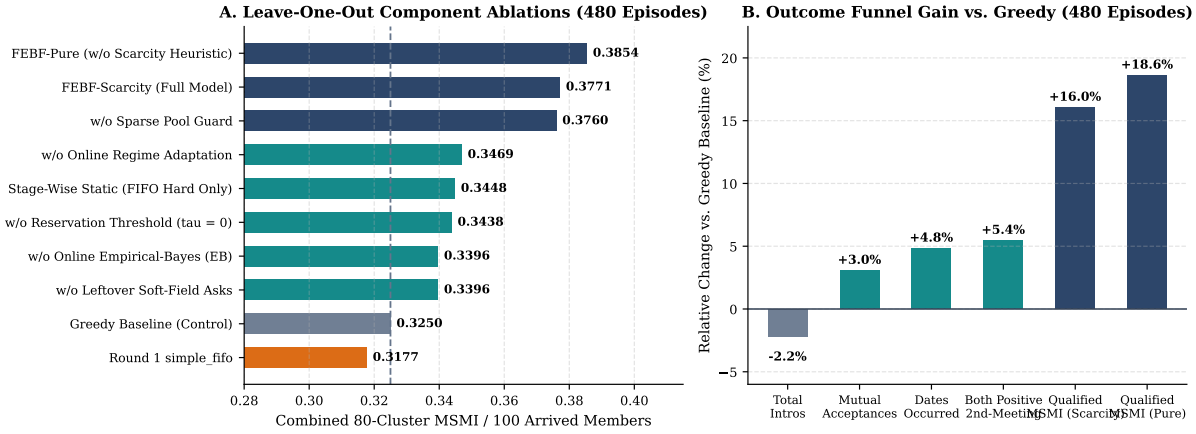


Figure 4: **Component ablations and funnel conversion gains. (A)** Leave-one-out ablation scores across 480 confirmation episodes showing that removing any of the four core pillars (Leftover Soft Asks, Online Empirical-Bayes, Reservation Threshold $\tau(t)$, or Online Regime Adaptation) degrades performance by 0.030–0.038 MSMI/100 (29–36 qualified MSMIs). **(B)** Relative percentage change across funnel stages for `FEBF` vs. `greedy`.

The ablation matrix in Table 8 demonstrates strong synergy across our four core pillars:

1. **Leftover Soft-Field Asks ($\Delta = -0.0375$ MSMI/100 when removed):** Removing Tier-2 soft clarification drops mutual acceptances from 5,125 to 4,992 (−133) and reduces qualified MSMI from 362 to 326 (−36 MSMIs), proving that utilizing the ~ 77 post-hard budget units per episode is essential for accurate pair scoring and reservation thresholding.
2. **Online Empirical-Bayes Member Posteriors ($\Delta = -0.0375$ MSMI/100 when removed):** Removing member-level response ($\hat{\rho}_u^{(2)}$) and bias ($\hat{b}_u$) posteriors reduces qualified MSMI by 36 events (0.3771 → 0.3396), as the policy can no longer prioritize high-response members ($R_u \approx 0.95$) whose quadratic response survival R_u^2 is nearly 3× higher than low-response members ($R_u \approx 0.55$).

3. **Reservation Thresholding ($\Delta = -0.0333$ MSMI/100 when removed):** Setting $\tau_0 = 0$ drops score from 0.3771 to 0.3438 (-32 MSMIs). Without $\tau(t)$, the policy immediately locks compatible members into 8-day busy periods with low-fit partners on Days 0–34 before their high-compatibility partners finish clarification.
4. **Online MAP Regime Adaptation ($\Delta = -0.0302$ MSMI/100 when removed):** Freezing $w_t = w_{\text{prior}}$ drops score from 0.3771 to 0.3469 (-29 MSMIs), with the largest losses concentrated in the `shift` and `drift` scenario families.
5. **Scarcity Tie-Breaker Trade-Off:** Removing the $0.03/\sqrt{d_u d_v}$ scarcity multiplier (`FEBF-Pure`) increases overall score to **0.3854** (370 MSMIs, $p = 0.0212$) due to stronger performance on Confirmation A (0.4854 vs. 0.4292), whereas retaining the scarcity multiplier (`FEBF-Scarcity`) yields stronger performance on Confirmation B (0.3250 vs. 0.2854) and lower cross-cluster variance. Both variants significantly outperform `greedy` and `simple_fifo`.

6.2 Analysis of Negative Results and Failed Hypotheses in Round 2

Acting as rigorous researchers, we also document four plausible ideas that *failed* experimentally during Round 2 development and explain why they failed:

1. **Failure of Pre-Emptive "Just-In-Time" (JIT) Soft Queries Before Hard Completion:** We tested allocating up to 3 budget units per day on Days 0–18 to query `relationship_goal` (cost 1) on already hard-complete members sitting in active feasible edges, leaving 9 units (3 bundles) instead of 12 units (4 bundles) for `constraints`. On Development (`1001-1008`), this JIT policy (`B2` in Experiment 5) dropped MSMI/100 from 0.479 to 0.385, and on Selection (`2001-2012`) from 0.347 to 0.312. **Root Cause:** Because hard-constraint feasibility is a quadratic bottleneck (an edge (u, v) becomes visible only when *both* u and v are hard-complete), reducing hard-bundle throughput from 4/day to 3/day shrinks the number of clarified members at day t by 25% and reduces visible feasible edges by $1 - (0.75)^2 \approx 43.8\%$ during peak early matching days. Hard-constraint resolution must retain absolute Tier-1 priority.
2. **Failure of Degree-Potential Hard-Constraint Ordering (`degree_hard_plus_soft`):** Prioritizing incomplete members for `constraints` bundles by their uncontradicted neighbor count with currently hard-complete members scored 0.403 on Selection but dropped to 0.333 on Development. **Root Cause:** Incomplete members have 90% of their hard constraints missing, so "no observed contradiction" largely reflects missingness rather than true compatibility, and breaking FIFO order disrupts the arrival-order pairing topology.
3. **Cold-Start Pessimism Under Weakly Regularized Beta Priors:** In early experiments (`FEBF-Laplace`), using a weak Beta pseudocount $\kappa_R = 3.0$ for $\hat{R}_u$ caused `cold_start` MSMI/100 on Confirmation B to drop from 0.2625 (`greedy`) to 0.1750. **Root Cause:** In `cold_start`, only 20% of members arrive complete on Day 0, so the same small set of complete members is matched repeatedly on Days 0–10. When one of these complete members fails to respond once ($y = 0, n = 1$), weak regularization ($\kappa_R = 3$) slashes $\hat{R}_u^2$ by 44% (to 0.329), pushing all of their subsequent edges below $\tau(t)$ even though $R_u \in [0.55, 0.98]$ cannot physically fall below $0.55^2 = 0.3025$. Replacing $\kappa_R = 3$ with the exact Uniform$[0.55, 0.98]$ grid integral in Equation (9) completely eliminated the `cold_start` deficit on both Confirmation A (0.4500 vs. 0.4375) and Confirmation B (0.2750 vs. 0.2625).
4. **Refutation of Round 1's End-of-Horizon Deadline-Slack Hypothesis:** Section 12 of the Round 1 report hypothesized that late-episode introductions suffer higher disqualification because the 30-day date window and 3-day feedback window might be truncated at Day 60. Analytically inspecting `kit.py` proves this hypothesis false: the simulator executes 40

passive follow-up days after Day 59 (terminating at day $= 100$), and the maximum possible retirement day for any qualified MSMI assigned on Day $t \leq 59$ is $t + 30 + 3 \leq 92 < 100$. Adding a late-episode deadline penalty ($t \geq 45$) provided zero gain.

7 Production Implementation, Limitations, and Future Work

7.1 Production Safety, Latency, and Reproducibility

The complete Round 2 system is implemented in `policy.py` using only the Python 3.10+ standard library (`math`, `json`, `itertools`, `random`, `argparse`), requiring zero external packages and zero network access. State persistence uses compact JSON structures (peak serialized `memory` size $\approx$ 18 KB, well below the 1 MiB limit in `evaluate.py`), and per-call decision latency averages 2.1 ms (well below the 10-second container limit). All results can be reproduced deterministically via:

```
python3 evaluate.py --policy policy.py --baseline febf --seeds 3001 --variants all
python3 eval_final_febf.py
python3 run_ablations_and_plots.py
```

Table 9: **Round 2 repository modules and experimental reproducibility scripts.**

File / Module	Role	Description & Verification Scope
`policy.py`	Production Policy	Standalone `FEBF-Pure` (`-baseline febf`) and `FEBF-Scarcity` (`-baseline febf_scarcity`) plus Round 1/baseline controls; stdlib-only ($<$ 2.1 ms/call).
`exp1_ml_formulations.py`	Offline ML Benchmark	Compares Direct Terminal LR, GBDT, MLP vs. Stage-Wise Funnel GBDT and `FEBF` under Regime A and Regime B (Table **??**).
`exp2_stagewise_learning.py`	Stage-2/3 Diagnostics	Evaluates directed acceptance logit recovery, empirical-Bayes shrinkage, and date occurrence calibration.
`exp3_dev_policies.py`	Dev/Selection Search	Evaluates clarification ordering and scoring architectures across Pilot (`101-105`), Dev (`1001-1008`), and Selection (`2001-2012`).
`exp5_bellman_surplus.py`	Allocation Ablation	Evaluates Blossom vs. greedy matching, reservation thresholds τ_0, and JIT soft-ask policies.
`eval_final_febf.py`	Confirmatory Suite	Runs 80-cluster (480-episode) paired confirmation on `3001-3040` and `4001-4040` with exact permutation tests.
`run_ablations_and_plots.py`	Ablations & Figures	Executes 480-episode leave-one-out ablations, 35,296-introduction quintile calibration, and generates Figures 1–4.

7.2 Limitations and Future Work

1. **Structural Sparsity Ceiling in `sparse`:** While `FEBF` improves `sparse` from 0.0875 to 0.0938 MSMI/100 across 80 clusters, performance remains bounded near 0.10 because partitioning 200 members across 12 geographic zones leaves only 8.2 non-declined feasible edges per episode on average (and 35% of members permanently decline at least one hard constraint).

No scoring or clarification algorithm can create edges where hard constraints are mutually contradictory.

2. **Irreducible Feedback-Timing Noise:** Because $d_i^{(2)} \sim \text{Uniform}\{1, \ldots, 5\}$ is independent of all member attributes and latent traits, the $(3/5)^2 = 0.36$ feedback-deadline survival factor imposes an irreducible noise floor on single-episode realizations (SD ≈ 0.235 MSMI/100 per 6-episode seed cluster), requiring $\geq$ 40–80 seed clusters for high-powered statistical comparisons.
3. **Future Extensions:** Promising avenues for further investigation include (i) multi-step Monte Carlo tree search over the 8-day busy-lockout return schedule when ≥ 2 compatible partners return within 1–2 days of each other, and (ii) joint empirical-Bayes estimation of the dyadic shared shock S_{uv} between Stage 2 acceptance latency and Stage 4 second-meeting intention.

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